POLI10302 / 20 CREDITS

Making Sense of Politics.

Course handbook

Your guide to the module, the weekly sessions and the work you will produce.

WORKING DRAFT

Updated 12 November 2026

Deadlines, weekly readings and some teaching arrangements are still to be confirmed. Use Canvas for current announcements.

FIND WHAT YOU NEED

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WELCOME

Start here

You do not need prior experience of programming or statistics. We will build the skills step by step.

Use these links whenever you need to find a class, open your materials or ask for help. Canvas links require your University sign-in.

Find your timetable

Check your assigned class, time and room.

Open your personal timetable

Prepare for this week

Find announcements, readings and preparation in the course area.

Open Canvas modules

Check what to submit

Use the current briefs and checklists; deadlines remain to be confirmed.

Assessment 1 · Assessment 2

Ask the teaching team

Find current tutor details and office-hour arrangements on the course homepage.

Course homepage · Email Jack Bailey

Software or access problems: Student IT support.
Study or wellbeing support: SoSS Student Support Hub.

PLAN YOUR TERM

Course at a glance

Lectures run in Weeks 1–10. Workshops run in Weeks 2–11, so the workshop number is one behind the teaching week.

Use your personal timetable for calendar dates, times and rooms. The sequence below is the current teaching plan.

WEEK	LECTURE	WORKSHOP
1	Getting started	No workshop
2	Surveys and public opinion	1. Getting started with data and R
3	Measurement and trends	2. Prepare data
4	Groups and descriptive statistics	3. Analyse data
5	Visualisation and data journalism	4. Visualise data
6	Experiments and causation	5. Assessment 1 support
7	Treatment effects	6. Describe experimental data
8	Regression	7. Estimate treatment effects
9	Statistical uncertainty	8. Interpret statistical evidence
10	Skills and careers	9. Communicate research findings
11	No lecture	10. Assessment 2 support

Assessment support: Workshop 5 in Week 6 supports the data journalism article. Workshop 10 in Week 11 supports the experimental report.

THE MODULE

Course description

How can we tell what people think, why politics changes and whether an intervention makes a difference?

Politics is full of claims about what people believe and what causes them to act. Some rest on careful evidence; others rely on anecdotes, selective examples or assumptions. This module gives you tools to ask sharper questions and examine those claims using data.

PART 1

Describe the political world

Find, prepare and analyse public-opinion data in R. Create a clear visualisation with ggplot2, then explain a finding in a data journalism article for a general audience.

PART 2

Investigate cause and effect

Explore why random assignment helps us answer causal questions. Compare experimental groups, use a simple regression to estimate a treatment effect, and report your findings and their uncertainty.

Learn through practice

Lectures introduce political questions and the ideas we need to investigate them. Workshops give you time to try the methods, discuss interpretations and ask for help. Regular practice helps you build confidence with unfamiliar tools.

Question the evidence

Throughout the module, ask where data come from, what they measure, whom they represent and what they cannot tell us. A good argument is informative and appropriately cautious.

WHAT YOU WILL LEARN

Course aims

Build the confidence to ask political questions and answer them with evidence.

01

Answer political questions

Turn curiosity into a question you can investigate. Choose relevant evidence, describe patterns and distinguish a relationship from a convincing causal explanation.

02

Work with political data

Find, prepare and analyse data in R. Summarise patterns, compare groups, create visualisations with ggplot2 and interpret a simple regression.

03

Evaluate evidence critically

Consider measurement, sampling and uncertainty. Explain what a result supports, what it leaves unresolved and how the design affects your interpretation.

04

Communicate with purpose

Write for different audiences. Produce an accessible data journalism article and an experimental report supported by relevant academic research.

These practical aims describe the module's learning journey. The formal approved learning outcomes remain subject to confirmation in the final handbook.

YOUR WORK

Assessments

Use each brief for full requirements and its checklist to review your submission.

ASSESSMENT 1

Data journalism article

Investigate your own political question using a YouGov tracker. Analyse it in R, include an original ggplot2 figure and write for a general audience.

Length	1,000 words ± 10%; reference list excluded
Weight	35% of the module grade
Deadline	To be confirmed on Canvas
Submit	One PDF on Canvas
Sources	At least 2 academic journal articles or books
Support	Workshop 5 · Week 6

Read the brief · Open the checklist

ASSESSMENT 2

Experimental report

Develop a hypothesis from research and analyse an experimental dataset in R. Interpret the effect and uncertainty, using at least one table or figure.

Length	2,000 words ± 10%; reference list excluded
Weight	65% of the module grade
Deadline	To be confirmed on Canvas
Submit	One PDF on Canvas
Sources	At least 5 academic journal articles or books
Support	Workshop 10 · Week 11

Read the brief · Open the checklist

Include your student ID, word count and reference list; omit your name. Assessment 2 questions and data are still to be confirmed. Check the final briefs before submitting.

BEYOND THE MODULE

Employability

Build examples of what you can do, explain how you did it and show why it matters.

Working with evidence is useful in research, journalism, public policy, charities and business. The module gives you concrete work to discuss in applications and interviews.

Find and work with evidence

Locate data, assess its source and prepare it for analysis. Keep a script that records your steps so you can explain and revisit them.

Use judgement

Compare groups, recognise limitations and distinguish correlation from causation. Interpret uncertainty alongside the size of a result.

Communicate clearly

Choose an appropriate graphic, explain a finding in plain language and adapt your writing to the audience.

KEEP AN EXAMPLE

Your assessments as evidence of skills

Assessment 1: survey data analysis in R, data visualisation with ggplot2, and communication to non-specialists.

Assessment 2: linear regression in R, causal inference from experiments, and statistical reporting.

At the guest event, ask how professionals use these skills. Afterwards, note one example from your own work that you could explain in an interview.

WORKING TOGETHER

Course expectations

Regular practice, curiosity and asking for help matter more than arriving with experience.

Before class

Check Canvas modules for readings, preparation and announcements. Use your personal timetable for the session time and location.

During class

Take part in the questions and activities. In workshops, work through the practical tasks at your own pace and ask your tutor when you get stuck. Discuss ideas respectfully and give others room to contribute.

Between sessions

Revisit the code. Run it, change one thing and explain what the output means. Save your scripts and note what remains unclear.

Before asking for feedback

Bring a specific question and the relevant data, code, output or draft. Explain what you tried and where the difficulty begins.

When submitting work

Acknowledge your sources and represent evidence honestly. Follow the current University and assessment guidance on academic integrity and permitted use of tools.

GET HELP EARLY

Questions about the module: teaching team on Canvas.
Software or access: Student IT support.
Study support or mitigating circumstances: Student Support Hub.

GETTING STARTED

Week 1
Getting started

Why use numbers to understand politics?

Lecture 1 · No workshop

BEFORE CLASS

Check your timetable and open the course area. Think of a political claim you would like to investigate.

Weekly readings and any required preparation: check Canvas. Readings are still being finalised.

LECTURE 1

Welcome and introduction

We begin with political questions and the role of evidence in answering them. We consider what quantitative data can reveal, what they can miss and how the module's two parts fit together.

Lecture materials · Materials to follow

NO WORKSHOP THIS WEEK

Use the time to find the course on Canvas and familiarise yourself with the materials.

TAKE AWAY

A political question and a first idea of the evidence you would need.

Check your understanding: Identify a political claim you would like to investigate. What evidence would help you assess it?

PART 1 · DATA SCIENCE

Week 2
Surveys and public opinion

How do we know what people think?

Lecture 2 · Workshop 1

BEFORE CLASS

Make sure you can open RStudio Desktop. If you cannot access it, ask for help before the workshop.

Weekly readings and any required preparation: check Canvas. Readings are still being finalised.

LECTURE 2

Surveys, samples and political evidence

We explore how surveys turn individual responses into evidence about public opinion. We ask how samples are recruited, what it means for a sample to be representative and where to find political data.

Lecture materials · Materials to follow

WORKSHOP 1

Getting started with data and R

Read a small table of YouGov results, make a simple calculation in R and save your first script.

Workshop materials · Materials to follow

TAKE AWAY

A saved R script containing your first calculation.

Check your understanding: Describe what a survey result measures and whose views it is intended to represent.

PART 1 · DATA SCIENCE

Week 3
Measurement and trends

How do we know whether opinion is changing?

Lecture 3 · Workshop 2

BEFORE CLASS

Reopen the R script you saved in Workshop 1 and try running it again.

Weekly readings and any required preparation: check Canvas. Readings are still being finalised.

LECTURE 3

Measurement and trends

We consider how political attitudes are measured, how a concept becomes a variable and how comparisons over time can help us identify change. We also ask when changes in wording or measurement complicate a comparison.

Lecture materials · Materials to follow

WORKSHOP 2

Prepare data

Begin finding and importing data, then inspect and prepare it in R. Practise selecting, filtering and cleaning data for analysis.

Workshop materials · Materials to follow

TAKE AWAY

A script that imports and prepares data for analysis.

Check your understanding: Check that observations being compared measure the same thing in a meaningful way.

PART 1 · DATA SCIENCE

Week 4
Groups and descriptive statistics

Who thinks what?

Lecture 4 · Workshop 3

BEFORE CLASS

Review the data-preparation steps from the previous workshop and note anything you want to revisit.

Weekly readings and any required preparation: check Canvas. Readings are still being finalised.

LECTURE 4

Groups and descriptive statistics

We use descriptive statistics to explore differences between groups. We consider proportions and other summaries, and ask how to describe a pattern without claiming more than the data support.

Lecture materials · Materials to follow

WORKSHOP 3

Analyse data

Summarise political data in R, compare groups or periods and identify a finding worth explaining.

Workshop materials · Materials to follow

TAKE AWAY

A descriptive summary and a clearly stated finding.

Check your understanding: Describe a difference in plain language, including the groups and units being compared.

PART 1 · DATA SCIENCE

Week 5
Visualisation and data journalism

What makes a visualisation trustworthy?

Lecture 5 · Workshop 4

BEFORE CLASS

Bring a finding from your practice analysis that you could explain in a chart.

Weekly readings and any required preparation: check Canvas. Readings are still being finalised.

LECTURE 5

Visualisation and data journalism

We examine how design choices shape the way readers understand evidence: labels, scales, colour and graphical integrity all matter. The second part introduces Assessment 1 and how to turn a finding into a clear article.

Lecture materials · Materials to follow

WORKSHOP 4

Visualise data

Create, refine, label and export a chart using ggplot2.

Workshop materials · Materials to follow

TAKE AWAY

An exported chart with readable labels and a source credit.

Check your understanding: Choose a visual form that makes the comparison clear and gives readers the information they need.

PART 2 · EXPERIMENTS

Week 6
Experiments and causation

How can an experiment tell us what causes what?

Lecture 6 · Workshop 5

BEFORE CLASS

Read the Assessment 1 brief. Bring your question, data, code or a draft figure to Workshop 5.

Weekly readings and any required preparation: check Canvas. Readings are still being finalised.

LECTURE 6

Experiments and causal questions

We introduce counterfactual thinking, treatment and control groups, and random assignment. We ask why association alone may not tell us what caused an outcome, and how an experiment can help.

Lecture materials · Materials to follow

WORKSHOP 5

Assessment 1 support

Bring your question, data, code or a draft figure. Use the session to develop your article and troubleshoot with your tutor.

Workshop materials · Materials to follow

TAKE AWAY

A clearer next step for your data journalism article.

Check your understanding: Explain the difference between a descriptive pattern and a causal claim.

PART 2 · EXPERIMENTS

Week 7
Treatment effects

How do we measure an effect?

Lecture 7 · Workshop 6

BEFORE CLASS

Revisit the distinction between treatment and control, and think about what the experiment measures.

Weekly readings and any required preparation: check Canvas. Readings are still being finalised.

LECTURE 7

Comparing treatment and control

We define outcomes and treatment effects, compare group means and consider why an estimated effect can differ across samples. We also ask whether the size of a difference matters in political terms.

Lecture materials · Materials to follow

WORKSHOP 6

Describe experimental data

Identify the treatment and outcome, calculate group means and compare the results.

Workshop materials · Materials to follow

TAKE AWAY

Treatment and control group means and their difference.

Check your understanding: Interpret a difference between treatment and control groups in the units of the outcome.

PART 2 · EXPERIMENTS

Week 8
Regression

Why use regression to analyse experiments?

Lecture 8 · Workshop 7

BEFORE CLASS

Review your treatment and control group summaries from Workshop 6.

Weekly readings and any required preparation: check Canvas. Readings are still being finalised.

LECTURE 8

From group differences to regression

We introduce simple linear regression as a way to estimate an experimental treatment effect. We interpret the intercept and treatment coefficient and connect the model to a difference in group means.

Lecture materials · Materials to follow

WORKSHOP 7

Estimate treatment effects

Fit a simple model using lm() in R and interpret its coefficients.

Workshop materials · Materials to follow

TAKE AWAY

A regression estimate and an explanation of its treatment coefficient.

Check your understanding: Explain what a treatment coefficient says about the difference between groups.

PART 2 · EXPERIMENTS

Week 9
Statistical uncertainty

How certain are we about an effect?

Lecture 9 · Workshop 8

BEFORE CLASS

Reopen your regression output and identify the intercept and treatment coefficient.

Weekly readings and any required preparation: check Canvas. Readings are still being finalised.

LECTURE 9

Uncertainty and differences in effects

We interpret confidence intervals and p-values alongside the size and direction of an estimate. We also consider why an average effect may not describe every group, and why subgroup claims need careful evidence.

Lecture materials · Materials to follow

WORKSHOP 8

Interpret statistical evidence

Extract estimates and measures of uncertainty and practise explaining them; an interaction exercise may be offered as an extension.

Workshop materials · Materials to follow

TAKE AWAY

An interpretation of an estimate, its confidence interval and p-value.

Check your understanding: Describe an estimate and its uncertainty without treating statistical significance as the whole story.

LOOKING AHEAD

Week 10
Skills and careers

Where can these skills take you?

Lecture 10 · Workshop 9

BEFORE CLASS

Prepare a question for the guest speakers. Bring your experimental results to the workshop.

Weekly readings and any required preparation: check Canvas. Readings are still being finalised.

LECTURE 10

Guest event and professional practice

Hear from professionals about how they use quantitative and analytical skills. Reflect on the questions they ask, the evidence they use and the ways they communicate their findings.

Lecture materials · Materials to follow

WORKSHOP 9

Communicate research findings

Prepare a results table or figure, document your analysis and practise writing up an experimental result.

Workshop materials · Materials to follow

TAKE AWAY

A results table or figure and a short explanation of the finding.

Check your understanding: Connect a skill you have practised to an example you could discuss in an application or interview.

LOOKING AHEAD

Week 11
Assessment 2 support

How do I bring my analysis together?

No lecture · Workshop 10

BEFORE CLASS

Read the Assessment 2 brief. Bring your script, results or draft, plus a specific question for your tutor.

Weekly readings and any required preparation: check Canvas. Readings are still being finalised.

There is no lecture this week. Use the time to bring together your question, literature, analysis and interpretation.

WORKSHOP 10

Assessment 2 support

Bring your data, script, results or draft and use the session to work on the experimental report with help from your tutor.

Workshop materials · Materials to follow

TAKE AWAY

A clear plan for the remaining revisions to your experimental report.

Check your understanding: Check that your report answers its question, interprets uncertainty and explains the study's limitations.

KEEP EXPLORING

Further reading

Choose a resource that fits what you want to practise next. These are optional starting points after the module.

R for Data Science · 2nd edition

Hadley Wickham, Mine Çetinkaya-Rundel and Garrett Grolemund. Start with Chapter 2, Workflow: basics; revisit Chapter 7 when practising data import.

Read Chapter 2 online · Chapter 7 · Free online

Data Visualization: A Practical Introduction

Kieran Healy. Start with Chapter 1, Look at Data, to think about how to read and evaluate graphics, then work through the practical examples.

Open the online book · Free online

The Effect

Nick Huntington-Klein. Begin with the material on research design and causality before moving to more demanding methods. A useful next step beyond the module.

Open the online book · Free online

Field Experiments

Alan Gerber and Donald Green. A more demanding guide to experimental design, analysis and interpretation. Use it when you want to explore experiments in greater depth.

Book information · Check library access

For books and other resources, search the University Library. You can also practise with a question of your own using YouGov's political trackers.